

Heidegger on Being and the World

Wednesdays at 1pm in 1008 B, Cathedral of Learning

Bob Brandom (rbrandom@pitt.edu)

The course website, with a week-by-week schedule and all the readings, is available at:

<https://spaceofreasons.netlify.app/courses/heidegger-2026/>

Or by drilling down under the “Courses” tab from my Pitt website:

<https://sites.pitt.edu/~rbrandom/>

Week 6: September 30, 2026

The Existentials of Dasein: Befindlichkeit, Verstehen, and Rede From Auslegung to Festlegung

Plan:

Recap: Trifurcation of ontological vocabularies by modality of relations defining the roles that are the Being of beings.

Vorhandensein: alethic modality. Modal Kant-Sellars thesis.

Zuhandensein: axiological normative modality. Appropriateness, correctness.

Dasein: attitude-dependent deontic modality. Commitment (Festlegung), not just deontic authority/responsibility.

Befindlichkeit (situatedness): and Geworfenheit (thrownness), as conditioning Verstehen and Rede.

World-poor (Welt-arm) Animals:

Stimulus-response behaviorism, and Dennett’s response.

Hegelian triadic model of affordances: desire/activity/significance, e.g. hunger/eating/food.

Verstehen (understanding) = Umsicht + Auslegung.

Auslegung (interpretation).

Content: something as something, this-such.

Modality: axiological normative.

Rede (discourse or telling).

Content: propositional, if-then.

Modality: attitude-dependent deontic normative = commitment (Festlegung, Bindung).

Gerede and Authentic Rede.

Discourse (Rede) is existentially equiprimordial with state-of-mind (Befindlichkeit, situatedness) and understanding (Verstehen). [§34 203]

[W]e must inquire into the basic forms in which it is possible to articulate anything understandable, and to do so in accordance with significations; and **this articulation must not be confined to entities within-the-world which we cognize by considering them theoretically, and which we express in sentences.** [§34 209]

But if deliberation is to be able to operate in **the scheme of the 'if-then'**, concern must already have 'surveyed' a context of involvements (Bewandtnisganze) and have an understanding of it. That which is considered with an 'if' must already be understood **as** something or other. **This does not require that the understanding of equipment be expressed in a predication. The schema 'something as something' has already been sketched out beforehand in the structure of one's pre-predicative understanding.** [§69 411]

Kant:

The same function that gives unity to the different representations in a judgment also gives unity to the mere synthesis of different representations in an intuition, which, expressed generally, is called the pure concept of understanding. (A79 / B104–105)

Dieselbe Funktion, welche den verschiedenen Vorstellungen in einem Urteile Einheit gibt, die gibt auch der bloßen Synthesis verschiedener Vorstellungen in einer Anschauung Einheit, welche, allgemein ausgedrückt, der reine Verstandesbegriff heißt.

Sellars (*Science and Metaphysics*):

An intuition is a representation of a 'this-such'... Intuitions are representations of the form 'this-F' (e.g., 'this red cube'). (SM I.§§4–7)

Intuitions are, so to speak, 'this-suches' rather than 'this is suches'.(SM I.§23)

To have an intuition of a red cube is to represent 'this red cube', which is a singular term, whereas to judge is to represent 'this red cube is P' or 'this is a red cube'. (SM I.§25)

The synthesis of apprehension which produces an intuition is a **conceptual** synthesis... It yields a representation of the form 'thisS' or 'thisS **ast**'. (SM I.§36)

Auslegen articulates the “something as something” (this-such) structure implicit in Verstehen: ‘This hammer’.

Aussage articulates the propositional structure of explicit Rede: ‘This is a rock’.

The existential ontological foundation of language is discourse or talk [Rede]. [§34 203]

<u>Verstehen</u>	<u>Rede</u>
Umsicht : Auslegung	:: Gerede : Aussage

...assertion is derived from interpretation, and is an extreme case of it. [§34, 203]

In discourse the intelligibility of Being-in-the-world (an intelligibility which goes with a state-of-mind) is articulated according to significations; and **discourse is this articulation**.

The items **constitutive for discourse** are:

what the discourse is about (what is talked about);

what is said-in-the-talk, as such;

the communication;

and the making-known. [§34 206]

Discoursing or talking is the way in which we articulate 'significantly' the intelligibility of Being-in-the-world. Being-with belongs to Being-in-the-world, which in every case maintains itself in some definite way of concerned Being-with-one-another. Such Being-with-one-another **is discursive as assenting or refusing**, as demanding or warning, as pronouncing, consulting, or interceding, **as 'making assertions', and as talking in the way of 'giving a talk'**. [§34 204]

That which the discourse is about [**das Worüber** der Rede] does not necessarily or even for the most part serve as the theme for an assertion in which one gives something a definite character....

In any talk or discourse, there is **something said-in-the-talk** as such [ein Geredetes as solches]—something said as such [das . . . Gesagte als solches]... In this "something said", discourse communicates. [§34 205]

Whenever **something is communicated in what is said-in-the-talk**, all talk about anything has at the same time the character of expressing itself [Sichaussprechens]. In talking, Dasein expresses itself [spricht sich . . . aus].... [§34 205]

...the analysis of Rede as essentially involving **das Worüber**, what one is talking *about*, and **das Geredetes**. [§34 204-5]

These are the successors, for the *apophantical* 'as', of the *hermeneutic* 'as' of Auslegung, "something as something", a 'this-such'.

The Worüber of Rede corresponds to the 'this' of Auslegung.

The Geredetes of Rede corresponds to the 'such' of Auslegung.

The difference is the "if...then__" *inferential* structure of the relations articulating *assertion* (Aussage).

Circumspection operates in the involvement-relationships of the context of equipment which is ready-to-hand. Moreover, it is subordinate to the guidance of a more or less explicit survey of the equipmental totality of the current equipment-world and of the public environment which

belongs to it. This survey is not just one in which things that are present-at-hand are subsequently scraped together. What is essential to it is that one should have a primary understanding of the totality of involvements within which factual concern always takes its start. Such a survey illumines one's concern, and receives its 'light' from that potentiality-for-Being on the part of Dasein for the sake of which concern exists as care. In one's current using and manipulating, the concernful circumspection which does this 'surveying', brings the ready-to-hand closer to Dasein, and does so **by interpreting what has been sighted. This specific way of bringing the object of concern close by interpreting it circumspectively, we call "deliberating" [Uberlegung]. The scheme peculiar to this is the 'if-then';** if this or that, for instance, is to be produced, put to use, or averted, then some ways and means, circumstances, or opportunities will be needed. [§69 410]

Kant:

Judgment is nothing other than the way to bring given cognitions to the objective unity of apperception. (B143)